Aniza Pala-Mohamad

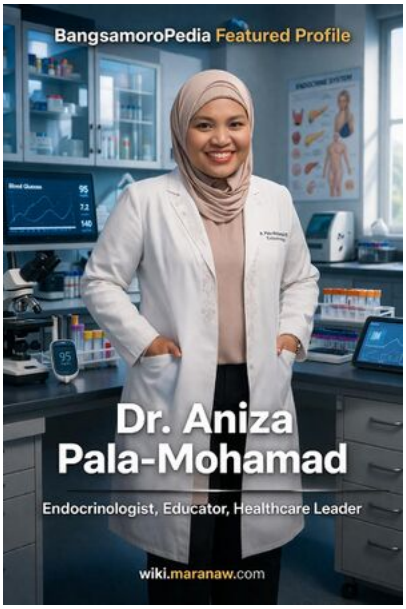
Dr. Aniza Barandia Pala-Mohamad is a distinguished Maranao physician, educator, and healthcare leader whose career has centered on bridging specialized medical care gaps across the BARMM. As the first Maranao endocrinologist to establish practice in the cities of Marawi and Iligan, Dr. Pala-Mohamad has spent over a decade advancing clinical excellence, training the next generation of internal medicine specialists, and championing health equity through both private and charitable care. Her institutional contributions at Amai Pakpak Medical Center in Marawi City and her pioneering research on genetic markers of diabetes in Filipino populations have cemented her legacy as both a clinician-researcher and an advocate for accessible, specialized healthcare in underserved communities.

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Early Life and Background

Dr. Aniza Barandia Pala-Mohamad was born and raised in Brgy. Poblacion, Kauswagan,Lanao del Norte, the land of beauty and bounty, where Muslims and Christians coexist in peace and unity. She is the daughter of Alice Mohamad Barandia and Marcone Pala. Her identity as a Maranao woman from a region historically marginalized in healthcare infrastructure shaped her understanding of the deep inequities in access to specialized medical care. The Maranao, often called the "People of the Lake" for their residence around Lake Lanao, have faced systemic barriers to quality healthcare, particularly in subspecialties like endocrinology, where expertise concentrates overwhelmingly in urban centers like Metro Manila and Cebu City. Her decision to return to her roots as a trained endocrinologist would, years later, prove transformative for her community.



Dr. Aniza Pala-Mohamad	
Specialization	Endocrinology, Diabetes, and Metabolism
Ethnic Affiliation	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Birth	Lanao del Norte, Philippines
Education	MSU College of Medicine (2005)
Residency Training	Internal Medicine, Vicente Sotto Memorial Medical Center (2010)
Fellowship Training	Endocrinology, Philippine General Hospital (2014)
Additional Qualifications	Master of Hospital Administration (MHA), Master of Business Administration (MBA)
Primary Affiliations	Amai Pakpak Medical Center, Marawi City; FK Specialists Clinic, Iligan City
Professional Memberships	Fellow, Philippine College of Physicians; Fellow, Philippine Society of Endocrinology, Diabetes and Metabolism

Academic Journey

Dr. Pala-Mohamad's educational trajectory reflects consistent academic excellence and deliberate pursuit of specialized training.

Undergraduate and Medical School

She earned her M.D. from the MSU College of Medicine in 2005, graduating in the **Top 10** of her class. This achievement at one of the Philippines' leading medical schools signaled her intellectual caliber and clinical aptitude early in her career. Her MSU degree rooted her in the academic traditions of Mindanao and connected her to an alumni network deeply invested in the region's health workforce.

Residency in Internal Medicine

Following her medical degree, Dr. Pala-Mohamad completed her internal medicine residency at the Vicente Sotto Memorial Medical Center in Cebu City in 2010. This three-year training exposed her to the breadth of systemic diseases and prepared her for the specialized study of metabolic disorders.

Fellowship in Endocrinology

In 2014, she completed her fellowship in Endocrinology, Diabetes, and Metabolism at the prestigious Philippine General Hospital (PGH) in Manila, one of the country's premier teaching institutions. This subspecialty training equipped her with advanced diagnostic and therapeutic expertise in disorders of the endocrine system, including diabetes, thyroid disease, and metabolic syndrome. Her completion of PGH's rigorous fellowship marked the culmination of nearly a decade of postgraduate training and positioned her among the select cohort of endocrinologists in the Philippines.

Advanced Management Training

Beyond clinical medicine, Dr. Pala-Mohamad pursued formal training in institutional leadership, earning a **Master of Hospital Administration (MHA)** and a **Master of Business Administration (MBA)**. These credentials demonstrate her strategic vision for healthcare systems and her commitment to leading not just at the bedside, but at the institutional level.

Professional Career and Practice

Since 2014, Dr. Pala-Mohamad has maintained a dual-city clinical practice, serving patients in both Marawi and Iligan. She operates in private fee-for-service settings and, critically, continues to offer charity clinic hours to ensure that specialized endocrine care reaches those unable to afford private consultation. This dual commitment to clinical excellence and health equity is the ethical cornerstone of her practice.

Primary Institutional Role: Amai Pakpak Medical Center

Dr. Pala-Mohamad's most significant institutional contribution has been her leadership at the Amai Pakpak Medical Center (APMC) in Marawi City, a key tertiary referral hospital serving the BARMM and the surrounding Lanao provinces. Her roles at APMC span both clinical leadership and workforce development.

Internal Medicine Residency Program

One of Dr. Pala-Mohamad's most enduring legacies is her instrumental role in establishing the **first Internal Medicine Residency Training Program in Lanao del Sur**. Prior to her involvement, the province had no accredited program to train internal medicine specialists locally, forcing aspiring physicians to migrate to other regions or cities. By pioneering this program at APMC, she created a pathway for medical graduates from Lanao del Sur and neighboring provinces to specialize without geographic dislocation.

The program's impact has been measurable and sustained. Under her leadership and mentorship, it has produced **49 accredited Internal Medicine specialists**. Many of these trainees have pursued further subspecializations, returning to serve their communities as cardiologists, nephrologists, gastroenterologists, and endocrinologists. In this way, Dr. Pala-Mohamad's program has seeded the development of subspecialty care across the BARMM region itself.

Departmental Leadership

Dr. Pala-Mohamad currently serves as the **Chairperson of the Internal Medicine Department** at APMC. In this role, she oversees clinical standards, resident training, and the strategic direction of the department. She previously served as the Training Officer, a position in which she ensured that resident education met Philippine Medical Association and specialty board standards.

Private Practice and Community Outreach

In Iligan City, Dr. Pala-Mohamad operates at the FK Specialists Clinic, where she sees patients with endocrine and metabolic disorders on a fee-for-service basis. Her clinical focus spans:

- Type 1 and Type 2 diabetes management and complication prevention
- Thyroid disorders (hypothyroidism, hyperthyroidism, thyroiditis)

- Adrenal and pituitary disorders
- Obesity and metabolic syndrome management
- Hormonal therapy and hormone replacement

Beyond individual consultations, she leads **lay health education forums** throughout Marawi and Iligan, teaching patients and community members about chronic disease prevention, medication adherence, and lifestyle modification. These public education sessions reflect her conviction that healthcare literacy is as essential to health equity as clinical expertise.

Research and Academic Contributions

Dr. Pala-Mohamad is not only a clinician but a researcher engaged in translational work that directly addresses the health needs of Filipino populations.

Pharmacogenomics Research

In 2023, she co-authored a peer-reviewed study published in the **Journal of the ASEAN Federation of Endocrine Societies (JAFES)** examining **genetic variants associated with poor sulfonylurea response in Filipino diabetic patients**. This research is particularly significant because it identifies molecular explanations for why certain Filipino patients fail to respond adequately to a commonly prescribed class of diabetes medications. The implications are direct: understanding population-specific genetic markers can guide more personalized drug selection and prevent futile or ineffective treatment courses. This type of pharmacogenomic research is still nascent in the Philippines, making Dr. Pala-Mohamad's contributions especially valuable for tailoring global diabetes guidelines to local genetic realities.

Clinical Outcomes and Nutrition Research

She has also investigated the relationship between **malnutrition and mortality in hospitalized Type 2 Diabetes patients**, a study addressing an often-overlooked intersection of metabolic disease and nutritional status in acute care settings. This research speaks to real-world clinical challenges: how do clinicians manage patients whose diabetes coexists with undernutrition or malnutrition, a surprisingly common scenario in resource-limited healthcare settings? Her work in this area informs both clinical protocols and institutional policies around nutritional support in diabetic inpatients.

Teaching and Mentorship

For over a decade, Dr. Pala-Mohamad has mentored **medical students at MSU College of Medicine**, where she conducts clinical rotations and lectures on endocrinology and metabolic disease. She has trained **hundreds of interns and residents** at APMC, many of whom now serve as physicians across Mindanao. Her didactic teaching includes both foundational lectures for trainees and **continuing medical education seminars** for practicing physicians in Marawi City, ensuring that local doctors remain current with advances in endocrinology, diabetes management, and metabolic disease.

Legacy and Impact

Dr. Aniza Pala-Mohamad's significance lies not in a single discovery or award, but in her embodiment of a principle that remains rare among specialist physicians in the Philippines: the commitment to build capacity and care in one's own community rather than consolidate expertise in privilege. Her career achievements cluster around three interconnected themes: pioneering representation, institutional capacity building, and equitable access.

Pioneering Representation

As the **first Maranao endocrinologist** to establish fulltime practice in Marawi and Iligan, Dr. Pala-Mohamad serves as a visible symbol of what is possible. Her presence in these cities challenges the historical assumption that specialized medicine is an urban or Manila-centric privilege. For Maranao women, in particular, she models both medical excellence and cultural rootedness, demonstrating that professional ambition and community commitment are not mutually exclusive. Her photo, her name, and her practice are themselves educational, signaling to the next generation of Maranao students that medicine at the highest levels is accessible to them.

Institutional Capacity Building

The Internal Medicine Residency Program she established at APMC is a permanent infrastructure, likely to outlast her tenure and continue training specialists decades into the future. By investing in systems rather than individual heroics, she has created scalable solutions to the workforce shortage in internal medicine across the BARMM. The 49 specialists trained under her watch are already embedded across the region, multiplying her impact exponentially.

Health Equity Through Dual Practice

Her maintenance of both a private practice and a charity clinic embodies a stance on healthcare justice: that specialized care should not be rationed by ability to pay. This is not merely idealistic; it is practical commitment, every week, to treating the uninsured alongside private patients. It reflects the values she articulates publicly: compassion, integrity, and empowerment.

Recognition and Professional Memberships

Dr. Pala-Mohamad holds full fellowship status with the **Philippine College of Physicians (PCP)**, the professional organization for Philippine physicians and the issuing body for medical licensure standards. She is also an active **Fellow of the Philippine Society of Endocrinology, Diabetes and Metabolism (PSEDM)**, the national subspecialty college for endocrinologists and metabolic disease specialists.

Challenges and Limitations

Despite her achievements, Dr. Pala-Mohamad's work occurs within constrained circumstances. The BARMM region, while developing, faces infrastructure limitations, irregular PhilHealth reimbursement rates that disadvantage rural providers, and ongoing security challenges that periodically disrupt healthcare delivery in Marawi proper. Her efforts to establish specialist care and training programs have frequently required her to improvise solutions and advocate for institutional support in an environment of scarcity. Her ability to persist and innovate within these constraints is itself remarkable.

Personal Values and Approach

In interviews and public statements, Dr. Pala-Mohamad emphasizes three core values that drive her professional life:

- **Compassion**: Recognition that illness brings both physical and emotional suffering, and that healing requires attentiveness to the whole person.
- **Integrity**: Commitment to evidence-based practice, honest communication with patients, and ethical decision-making even when convenience might suggest otherwise.
- **Empowerment**: Belief that patients and trainees thrive when equipped with knowledge, agency, and hope. Her educational forums and mentorship reflect this commitment to building capability in others.

Future Directions

Looking forward, Dr. Pala-Mohamad continues to expand endocrine care access within the BARMM and to mentor the next cohort of internal medicine residents at APMC. She remains engaged in clinical research, particularly in pharmacogenomics and outcomes research relevant to Filipino populations. Her vision, as articulated in various institutional forums, centers on sustainable, locally-rooted healthcare systems that neither depend indefinitely on external resources nor accept the inevitability of specialist care shortages.

See Also

- Amai Pakpak Medical Center
- Marawi City
- Mindanao State University
- Philippine General Hospital
- Maranao people
- BARMM
- Healthcare in the Philippines
- Endocrinology in the Philippines

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Categories

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